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DREAMING OF SNOWFLAKES Tourists take horse rides on Gulmarg's snowless slopes this winter

sledge is tied forlornly to an iron fence. "I have been waiting for tourists since 9 am to show them sketchy patches of snow in the upper reaches on horseback. But their numbers have dropped," he says. "In previous years, I'd earn Rs 1,500-2,000 a day carrying tourists on sledges; now I take home barely Rs 350-400...."

Almost all hotels in Gulmarg were booked till February-end by tourists, a majority of them skiers. But the snowless winter has led many to cancel their trip. India's first glass igloo café in the snow-filled courtyard of Kolahoi Green Heights has been hugely popular with tourists. Now, the empty glass igloo cubicles worry the hotel's general manager Hamid Masoodi. He also points out the plight of ski shops that rent out gear like skis, boots, goggles and snowboards to skiers. "We still have some tourists, but those who work in these shops and ski instructors have only the winter months to earn a living," says Masoodi.

With the absence of snow stalling the Khelo India winter games, authorities, too, are at a loss. A massive footfall of tourists in the past three winters had prompted the Kashmir tourism department to hold events like games and other activities. In the Golf Club premises, assistant director of tourism in Gulmarg, Javid-Ur-Rehman, says everything from ski lifts to hotels is ready to host tourists. The only missing thing is snow.

Meteorologically speaking, a lack of western disturbances (WD) has triggered this prolonged dry spell in January—the peak season for snowfall. The harshest period of winter, known in Kashmir as *chillai kalan*, would last 40 days from around December 21, with temperatures often hitting lows like minus 15 degrees Celsius, with an abundance of snow and rain. Over the past few years, that has been changing. The Indian Meteorological Department's regional director at Srinagar, Dr Mukhtar Ahmad, notes that a reduction in snowfall has a negative impact on Kashmir's agriculture, electricity, drinking water, irrigation and on already retreating glaciers. He attributes the dry spell to global warming and the El Nino phenomenon, when sea surface temperatures in the central and eastern Pacific Ocean rise by at least 0.5 degrees Celsius over the long-term average. "Earlier, precipitation was mainly in the form of snow and would begin from October till March," he says. "But now the winter span is limited to December and January. This year's dry January can be mostly attributed to the El Nino effect." ■

WARM WINTER

- **There has been little snowfall in Kashmir this winter**
- **IMD ascribes this to reduced western disturbances, itself the result of global warming and the El Nino effect**
- **Winter tourism in the ski resort of Gulmarg is badly hit, affecting livelihoods**
- **A snowless winter affects irrigation, electricity and drinking water supply in Kashmir**